

Habilidades Comunicativas en Lengua Extranjera
Profesional (Inglés)

Unit 4. Handling workplace interactions

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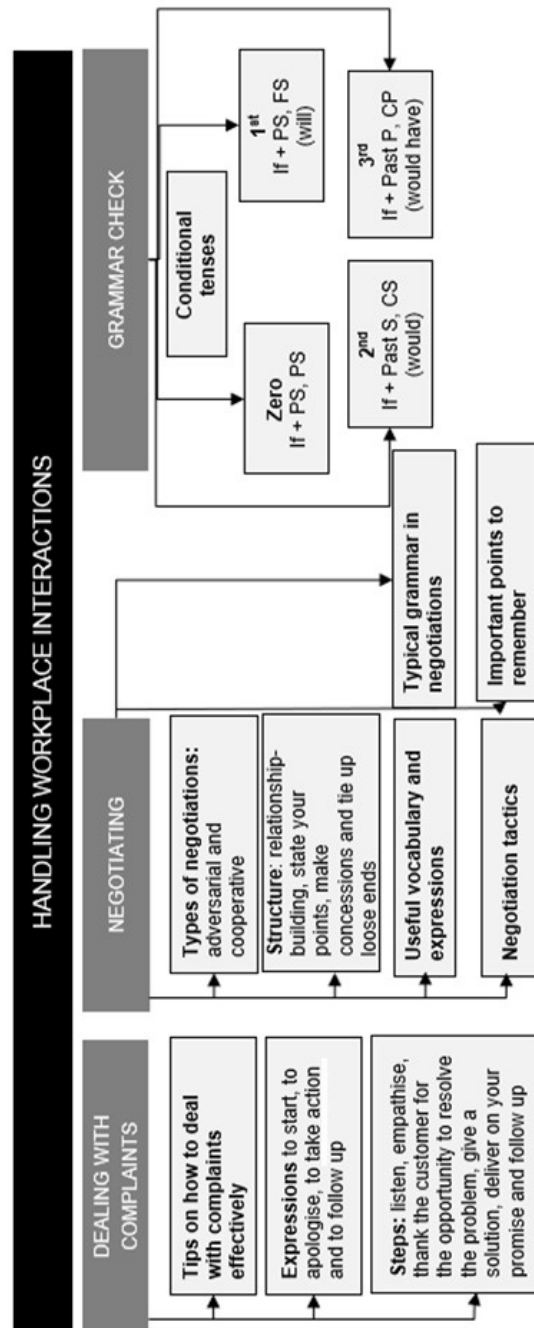
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4.1. Introduction and Objectives

Effective workplace interactions are essential for fostering a professional and productive environment. The ability to **handle complaints** with diplomacy and engage in successful **negotiations** plays a crucial role in maintaining positive relationships and resolving conflicts. **Strong communication skills, active listening, and problem-solving strategies** are key to ensuring that workplace discussions lead to constructive outcomes. In this unit, we will explore techniques for dealing with complaints professionally, negotiating effectively, and using appropriate language structures. Additionally, we will reinforce the use of **conditional tenses**, important for expressing possibilities, making polite requests, and formulating hypothetical scenarios.

- ▶ **Objective 1:** Understand the fundamentals of workplace interactions by analysing key strategies for effective communication.
- ▶ **Objective 2:** Develop techniques for addressing complaints professionally, focusing on active listening, empathy and problem-solving.
- ▶ **Objective 3:** Enhance negotiation skills by practicing strategies for reaching agreements and managing conflicts.
- ▶ **Objective 4:** Apply conditional tenses in workplace interactions to express hypothetical situations, offer solutions and make polite requests appropriately.

4.2. Dealing with complaints

How to deal with complaints

How to deal with complaints effectively

In the In Depth section, you can find a very interesting video on how to deal with complaints effectively.

Remember these key ideas:

- ▶ The customer isn't upset with you, they're upset with the situation, so **don't take it personally**.
- ▶ Try to **defuse** customer's **frustration**. Let them **vent**. Try **not to interrupt or contradict them**.
- ▶ The goal is to **calm the customer down** so you can look for a solution.
- ▶ **Remove the focus from yourself** and focus on the customer.
- ▶ **Stay detached**.
- ▶ Maintain an attitude of **caring** and **concern**, listen and respond with **empathy**, express your **understanding** and **acknowledge their problem**.

Customer complaints

To get some important vocabulary, let's read the following text.

CUSTOMER COMPLAINTS

A guide for small businesses

Many business people regard a customer complaint as a negative experience. However, if your business handles complaints properly, previously unhappy customers may start singing your praises. Consider a complaint as one of the best opportunities you have to show your commitment to creating another satisfied customer. Customer loyalty is one of the biggest assets a business has; fight for this loyalty - be passionate about it!

Complaints should be handled sympathetically and promptly. Some businesses believe that if they don't receive many complaints, their customers must be satisfied. Wrong! Only a few customers will complain to you. The majority will not return to your business and will tell others of their bad experience.

WHY SHOULD YOUR BUSINESS WELCOME COMPLAINTS?

Some published statistics say that:

- ▶ A typical business hears from only 4% of its dissatisfied customers, the other 96% just go quietly away and 91% of them will never come back;
- ▶ A typical dissatisfied customer tells more than 8 people about his or her problem;
- ▶ 7 out of 10 complaining customers will do business with you again if you resolve the complaint favourably.

HANDLING COMPLAINTS

Try putting the following points into practice:

- ▶ Set up a complaints handling system and train your staff to handle complaints well;
- ▶ Make it easy for customers to lodge a complaint.
- ▶ Welcome customers' complaints and deal with complaints promptly.

Now, find words and phrases in the text which mean the following:

- ▶ Take actions in order to solve a problem (two possible words).
- ▶ Showing your approval (idiom).
- ▶ Willingness to give your time and energy to something (noun).
- ▶ Useful qualities or advantages (plural noun).
- ▶ Repeatedly purchasing goods or services from one company; not changing for another company (phrase).
- ▶ Immediately (adverb).
- ▶ Not satisfied (adjective).
- ▶ To your advantage (adverb).
- ▶ Make an official complaint (phrase).

Steps

When dealing with complaints, make sure to **follow these steps**:

- ▶ Listen
- ▶ Empathise

- ▶ Thank the customer for the opportunity to solve the problem
- ▶ Find a solution
- ▶ Deliver on your promise
- ▶ Follow up

Useful expressions

The diagram consists of a dark grey rectangular box at the top with the text "TO START" in white, centered. A small downward-pointing arrow connects this box to a larger white rectangular box below it. Inside the white box is a bulleted list of six expressions for starting a complaint resolution.

TO START

- I understand...
- Yes, I see...
- **Could you tell me a little more about what/why/how happened?**
- Could you **clarify** what you mean when you say...?
- **Can you tell me exactly what happened?**
- **I'd like to summarise the situation** to make sure I understand everything correctly.

Figure 1. Expressions to start when dealing with complaints. Source: author original.

The diagram consists of a dark grey rectangular box at the top with the text "TO APOLOGISE" in white, centered. A small downward-pointing arrow connects this box to a larger white rectangular box below it. Inside the white box is a bulleted list of six expressions for apologizing.

TO APOLOGISE

- I'm sorry to hear that.
- **I understand how difficult/frustrating/disappointing that would be.**
- **I sincerely apologize.** We/I/The company would like to repair the damage (or resolve the situation).
- I apologize for the inconvenience/the problem.
- I'm terribly sorry. **We will work to resolve the problem immediately.**
- **We are going to solve this/take care/amend of it as quickly as possible.**

Figure 2. Expressions to apologise. Source: author original.

TO TAKE ACTION

- **Let me talk with ... to see what we can offer you to amend the situation.**
- **Would it be okay if I call you back in** a few hours with a solution?
- **I'd be happy to walk through all the steps** you need to repair the issue. (Common for software problems or technical problems discussed over the phone)
- **We'll issue a refund** immediately to resolve the issue.
- **Let me check with the manufacturer** (or the shippers, the programmers, etc.) to see what happened so we can fix this.
- **Let me review this situation** so I can identify the best solution.
- I will get back to you within 24 hours
- Let me discuss this with my manager/supervisor/sale team and get back to you later today with a solution.

Figure 3. Expressions to take action. Source: author original.

TO FOLLOW UP

Follow-up after you resolve the problem to make sure the customer is satisfied. You can follow-up with a quick phone call or email message.

- **I just wanted to follow-up with you regarding** [the problem] – is the issue fixed?
- **Did everything work out ok with** [the solution to the problem]?
- **I just want to make sure you are satisfied.**
- Was the problem resolved successfully? Is there anything else we can help you with?
- **Was everything satisfactory? Do you have any other concerns?**
- **Please be sure to let us know how we can help you if any other issues occur.**

Figure 4. Expressions to follow up. Source: author original.

4.3. Negotiating

Warm-up speaking

- ▶ In what situations do you negotiate?
- ▶ Who do you negotiate with? Think about both your work and your private life. What makes a good negotiator?
- ▶ How important are trust and liking in negotiations?
- ▶ Is there an important difference between the way you might approach one- off negotiations (e.g. selling your car) and negotiations as part of a long- term business relationship?
- ▶ How can you avoid being manipulated in a negotiation with a more experienced negotiator?

Negotiations

Negotiation is a process of bargaining (negociación, regateo) where agreement is reached between two or more parties. We all negotiate every day in a wide range of work and social situations. It is important to know how to negotiate effectively so we can reach better agreements for us.

There are two main styles of negotiation:

- ▶ **Adversarial bargaining:** the two sides take more rigid positions and give as few concessions as possible. They often open negotiations with unrealistic requests.
- ▶ **Cooperative bargaining:** is more likely to lead to both parties being satisfied not only with the deal they made but with the other party, which is important in a long-term business relationship.

Structure

Negotiations typically follow a structured process to ensure a productive and mutually beneficial outcome. The four key stages of a negotiation are **relationship-building, stating your points, making concessions, and tying up loose ends**. Each stage plays a crucial role in guiding the discussion toward an agreement that satisfies both parties.

1. Relationship-Building

Before diving into the main points of a negotiation, it is essential to establish a positive rapport with the other party. This stage involves: creating a cooperative atmosphere engaging in small talk or finding things in common and understanding the other party's need.

Example phrases:

- ▶ *"It's great to meet you. I've heard good things about your company."*
- ▶ *"Before we begin, I'd love to know more about your priorities for this negotiation."*

2. Stating Your Points

Once a good rapport is established, both parties present their positions and outline their key objectives. This stage involves: defining your goals and expectations, providing supportive arguments, identifying potential areas of compromise...

Example phrases:

- ▶ *"Our main objective today is to discuss pricing and delivery times."*
- ▶ *"Based on our research, we believe this offer is competitive and beneficial for both sides."*

3. Making Concessions

Negotiations often require compromise to reach an agreement that satisfies both parties.

Example phrases:

- ▶ *"If you can agree to a longer contract term, we can offer a discount."*
- ▶ *"We're open to adjusting the timeline if we can ensure a steady supply."*

4. Tying Up Loose Ends

The final stage involves summarizing the agreed terms, clarifying any remaining details, and ensuring both parties are aligned.

Example phrases:

- ▶ *"So, to confirm, we have agreed on a 10% discount for a six-month contract."*
- ▶ *"Let's put this in writing and schedule a follow-up meeting next week."*

Useful vocabulary

- ▶ **Build rapport:** develop an understanding of an ability to communicate with someone.
- ▶ **Probe interest:** find out the other side's expectation.
- ▶ **Begin the bargaining procedure:** start to negotiate the terms of an agreement.

- ▶ **Make proposals/offers:** make suggestions.
- ▶ **Make counter proposals/offers:** react to suggestions.
- ▶ **Reach a stalemate:** arrive at a situation which no progress can be made.
- ▶ **Make concessions:** allow or give up things in order to reach an agreement.
- ▶ **Reach a compromise:** arrive at an agreement where both parties reduce their demands in order to agree.
- ▶ **Work out the details:** discuss all the aspects of the deal.
- ▶ **Return to the negotiating table:** re-negotiate an agreement.

Negotiation tactics

- ▶ **The negotiation decoy:** add extra false interest to your agenda which you can bargain with, without affecting your real interests.
- ▶ **The extreme offer:** ask for more or offer less than expected in order to make concessions later.
- ▶ **Negotiation nibbling:** make one last small demand once the deal has been done hoping that your opponent will agree in order not to harm the agreement.
- ▶ **Good cop bad cop:** one member of the team is demanding and inflexible (the bad cop), the other appears to be pleasant and reasonable (the good cop). Your opponent will have to deal with the good cop.
- ▶ **Take it or leave it:** appear as if you're ready to break off the negotiation unless your interests are met.
- ▶ **Negotiation limits:** state limitations (for example: money or time), real or imagined, hoping that your opponent will make a concession to meet your limit.
- ▶ **Mention the competition:** make references to what your opponent's competitors are

offering in order to gain the concessions that you want.

- ▶ **Negotiation silence:** stop talking during the negotiation in the hope that your opponent will become uncomfortable and want to make a concession in order to break the silence.

Useful expressions

Opening the negotiation

So, shall we get down to business then?

Bargaining

Would you be willing to meet us halfway?

We'd need to see a bit more flexibility on terms of...

Asking for suggestions

How does that sound?

What are you proposing?

Rejecting a proposal

Come on, let's be reasonable here.

Unfortunately, I don't have any more room to negotiate this fee.

I'm afraid that's totally out of the question.

Accepting a proposal

I suppose we could manage that.

I think we could work something out here.

I think we could agree on...

I think that's fair enough

Organising a time-out

Could we take a time out? I need to think about this before I make a decision.

Shall we meet back here in half an hour?

Clinching the deal

Ok, it's a deal!

It's been a pleasure doing business with you.

Here's to a successful long term relationship.

Typical grammar in negotiations

- ▶ **Continuous forms of tenses.** Example: "We **were hoping** for a unit price of..."
- ▶ **Modifiers.** Example: "a bit", "a little".
- ▶ **Would/might/could.** Example: "I think we could...", "Would you be interested in...?"
- ▶ **Approximation.** Example: "sort", "around", "kind of".
- ▶ **Introductory softeners.** Example: "unfortunately", "I'm afraid that..."

Important points to remember

- ▶ **Never let emotion get in the way of making the right decision:** don't let that the behaviour of the other party triggers irrational decision making on your part.
- ▶ **Taking your position:** it is important not to take positions that are so strong that you lose sight of the truth.
- ▶ **Listen actively and ask questions:** ask questions to gain understanding of the other

side's interest, and explain your own.

- ▶ **Brainstorming:** common first step. It helps you understand your opinions, the other side's desires, the value of concessions...

3 steps to getting what you want in a negotiation

In the In Depth section, you can find a very interesting video about three steps to getting what you want in a negotiation.

4.4. Grammar check

Conditional tenses

Conditional tenses are **used to talk about possible or hypothetical situations** and their **consequences**. They usually have two parts:

- ▶ The “**if**” clause (the **condition**)
- ▶ The **main** clause (the **result**)

There are four main types of conditionals: zero, first, second and third, plus a special type called the mixed conditionals. Let's focus on the first four of them.

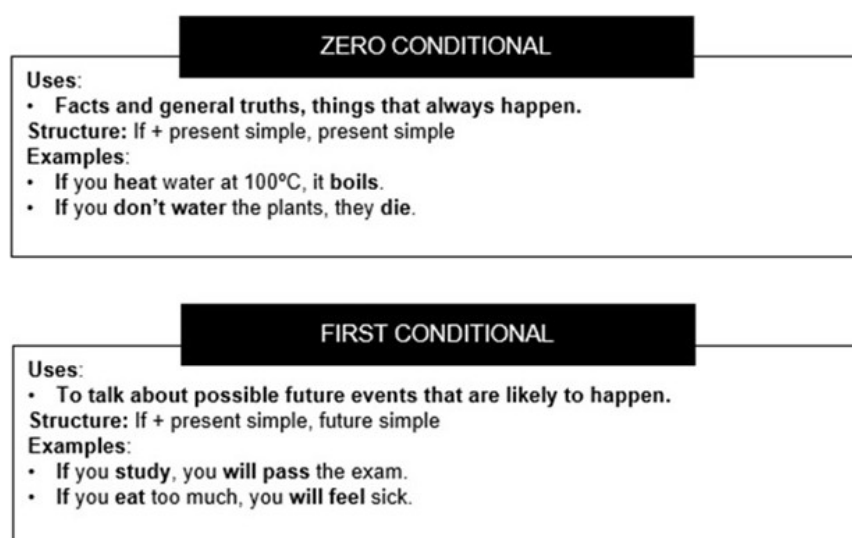


Figure 5. Zero and first conditional. Source: author original.

SECOND CONDITIONAL

Uses:

- Imaginary or unlikely situations in the future

Structure: If + past simple, conditional simple (would)

Examples:

- If I **had** a million dollars, I **would** travel the world.
- If she **knew** French, she **would** move to Paris.

THIRD CONDITIONAL

Uses:

- To talk about past situations that didn't happen and their hypothetical consequences.

Structure: If + past perfect, conditional perfect (would have + pp)

Examples:

- If I **had studied**, I **would have passed** the exam.
- If she **had called** me, I **would have helped** her.

Figure 6. Second and third conditional. Source: author original.

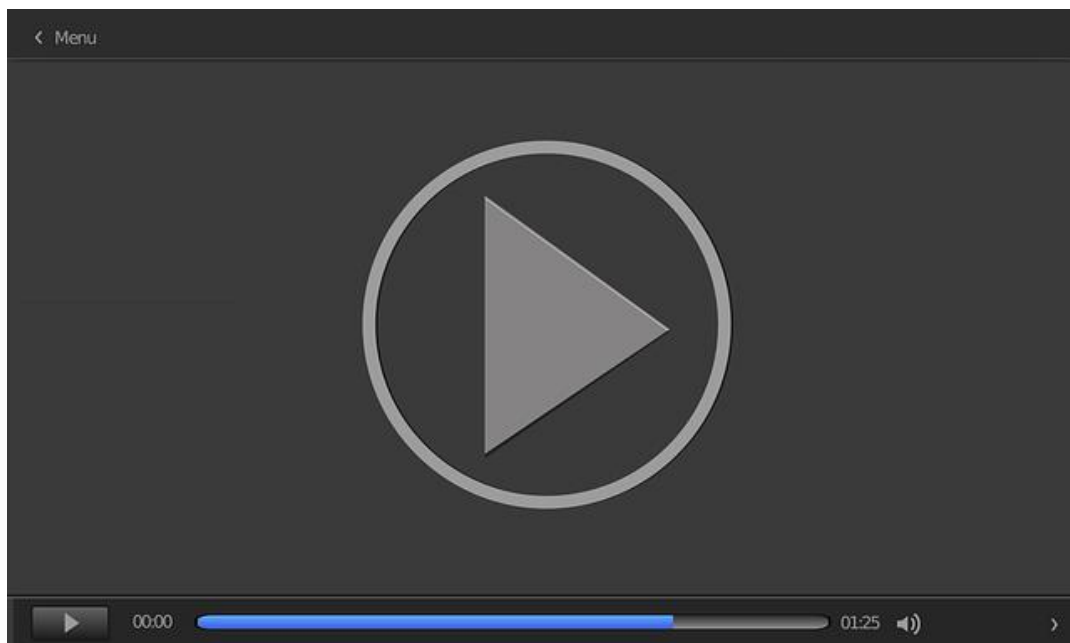
CONDITIONAL	USAGE	STRUCTURE	EXAMPLE
ZERO	General truths, facts	If + present simple, present simple	If you heat ice, it melts.
FIRST	Real, possible future situations	If + present simple, future simple (will)	If it rains, we will stay inside.
SECOND	Hypothetical/unreal present or future	If + past simple, conditional simple (would)	If I won the lottery, I would travel more.
THIRD	Imaginary past situations	If + past perfect, conditional perfect (would have + pp)	If she had studied, she would have passed the exam.

Figure 7. Summary of the main types of conditional tenses. Source: author original.

How to deal with complaints effectively

Skillsoft YouTube. (2018, 21 agosto). *Handling customer complaints: defusing frustration* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WphIXqTp_es

This is a very interesting video on how to deal with complaints effectively. It gives you important tips and information on how to handle complaints in the best way possible.



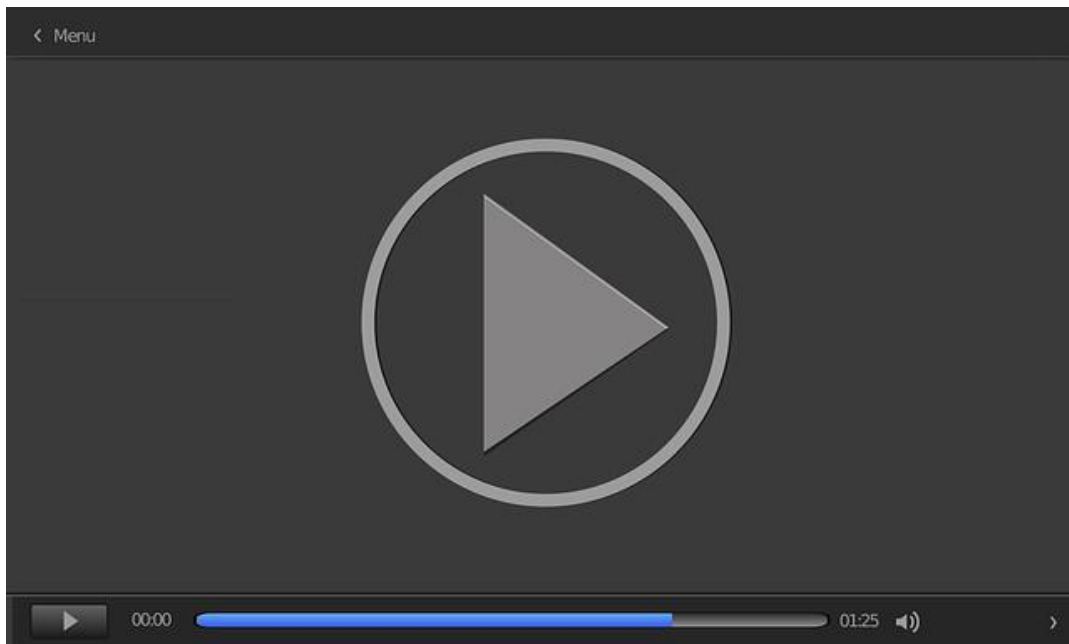
Accede al vídeo:

https://www.youtube.com/embed/WphIXqTp_es

3 steps to getting what you want in a negotiation

TED. (2021, 15 noviembre). *3 steps to getting what you want in a negotiation | The Way We Work, a TED series* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z3HJCQJ2Lmo>

This is a very interesting video about three steps to getting what you want in a negotiation. Negotiation is not about dominating, but about crafting a relationship.



Accede al vídeo:

<https://www.youtube.com/embed/Z3HJCQJ2Lmo>

Training 1. Dealing with complaints

Listen to four dialogues and complete the chart with your own words. Which complaint did you hear in each dialogue? What action was decided on in each dialogue? You can play the audio here: <https://www.linguahouse.com/esl-lesson-plans/business-english/complaining-and-apologizing/audioplayer/complaining-and-apologizing-ex2>

	COMPLAINT	SOLUTION
Dialogue 1		
Dialogue 2		
Dialogue 3		
Dialogue 4		

Solution 1

	COMPLAINT	SOLUTION
Dialogue 1	They have a problem with their latest delivery. It arrived three days late again and this is the 10 th time happening.	The driver was delayed at the border. The woman promised to look into the matter and do what she can to make sure it doesn't happen again.
Dialogue 2	There's a problem with the order. The casing on the television sets are cracked.	It must be due to bad-handling. The woman asked to send the goods back to give them replacements, plus a discount on the next order.
Dialogue 3	There's a mistake on their invoice. They were overcharged by 50 pounds.	Subtract the extra amount for the next invoice.
Dialogue 4	Lack of customer service to help her choose a laptop.	They're rather short-staffed at the moment. The man asked her to wait there until he finds someone to help her.

Training 2. Dealing with complaints

Listen to the audio again and complete the sentences. You can listen to the audio twice again.

- ▶ 1. I'm a____ we have a p____ w____ your latest delivery.
- ▶ 2. I'm very s____ about that. I'm afraid our diver was d____ at the border.
- ▶ 3. Leave it w____ me. I will l____ into the matter.
- ▶ 4. I'm c____ because we have a problem with our order.
- ▶ 5. What s____ to be the problem?
- ▶ 6. In what w____ are they d____?
- ▶ 7. I'm very sorry. This has never h____ before. It must be d____ to bad handling.
- ▶ 8. If you s____ us back the d____ sets, we'll send you r____ immediately and give you a d____ on your next order.
- ▶ 9. I a____ again for any i____ caused.
- ▶ 10. I'm calling about a m____ on our i____. It looks like you have o____ us by 50 pounds.
- ▶ 11. I'm sorry about this. Our accounts department m____ h____ made a small mistake when they processed your order.
- ▶ 12. We'll i____ a corrected invoice immediately.
- ▶ 13. I'm very sorry madam, we are rather s____ - ____ at the moment.
- ▶ 14. Please w____ here and I'll f____ someone to help you.

Solution 2

- ▶ 1. I'm **afraid** we have a **problem with** your latest delivery.
- ▶ 2. I'm very **sorry** about that. I'm afraid our diver was **delayed** at the border.
- ▶ 3. Leave it **with** me. I will **look** into the matter.
- ▶ 4. I'm **calling** because we have a problem with our order.
- ▶ 5. What **seems** to be the problem?
- ▶ 6. In what **way** are they **damaged**?
- ▶ 7. I'm very sorry. This has never **happened** before. It must be **due** to bad handling.
- ▶ 8. If you **send** us back the **damaged** sets, we'll send you **replacements** immediately and give you a **discount** on your next order.
- ▶ 9. I **apologise** again for any **inconvenience** caused.
- ▶ 10. I'm calling about a **mistake** on our **invoice** It looks like you have **overcharged** us by 50 pounds.
- ▶ 11. I'm sorry about this. Our accounts department **must have** made a small mistake when they processed your order.
- ▶ 12. We'll **issue** a corrected invoice immediately.
- ▶ 13. I'm very sorry madam, we are rather **short-staffed** at the moment.
- ▶ 14. Please **wait** here and I'll **find** someone to help you.

Training 3. Negotiations

Fill in the gaps with the vocabulary from the box about negotiations.

Agree – deal – flexibility – for – halfway – make – manage – mind – prepared –
reasonable – room – get – throw – work

- ▶ 1. So, shall we _____ down to business, then.
- ▶ 2. We were looking to _____ an order for 100 cases.
- ▶ 3. What sort of price did you have in _____?
- ▶ 4. We were hoping _____ a unit price of around \$4,50.
- ▶ 5. Would you be willing to meet us _____?
- ▶ 6. If you cut your delivery time by, say, 10 days, we should be _____ to pay the price you have proposed.
- ▶ 7. We'd need to see a bit more _____ on terms of payment.
- ▶ 8. Come on, let's be _____ here.
- ▶ 9. Unfortunately, I don't have any more _____ to negotiate this fee.
- ▶ 10. I suppose we could _____ that.
- ▶ 11. I think we could _____ something out here.
- ▶ 12. I think we could _____ on 3 weeks.
- ▶ 13. Sure, we can _____ that in.
- ▶ 14. Ok, it's a _____.

Solution 3

- ▶ 1. So, shall we **get** down to business, then.
- ▶ 2. We were looking to **make** an order for 100 cases.
- ▶ 3. What sort of price did you have in **mind**?
- ▶ 4. We were hoping **for** a unit price of around \$4,50.
- ▶ 5. Would you be willing to meet us **halfway**?
- ▶ 6. If you cut your delivery time by, say, 10 days, we should be **prepared** to pay the price you have proposed.
- ▶ 7. We'd need to see a bit more **flexibility** on terms of payment.
- ▶ 8. Come on, let's be **reasonable** here.
- ▶ 9. Unfortunately, I don't have any more **room** to negotiate this fee.
- ▶ 10. I suppose we could **manage** that.
- ▶ 11. I think we could **work** something out here.
- ▶ 12. I think we could **agree** on 3 weeks.
- ▶ 13. Sure, we can **throw** that in.
- ▶ 14. Ok, it's a **deal**.

Training 4. Negotiation dialogue

Fill in the gaps with the words and expressions from the box.

make – flexibility – mind – halfway – agree – get – for – reasonable – stalemate – deal

TechSolutions (T): So, shall we _____ (1) down to business, then?

Innovatech (I): Sure. We were looking to _____ (2) an order for 200 software licenses.

T: What sort of price did you have in _____ (3)?

I: We were hoping _____ (4) a unit price of around \$50 per license.

T: Hmm, that might be difficult. Would you be willing to meet us _____ (5) at \$60?

I: If you include a one-year technical support package, we should be able to accept that price.

T: That seems _____ (6). However, we'd need to see a bit more _____ (7) on the payment terms.

I: I understand. Unfortunately, I don't have any more room to negotiate on the support fees.

T: Alright, let's not reach a _____ (8) over this. How about we add a 6-month support extension instead?

I: That sounds good. I think we could _____ (9) on that.

T: Great. So, to clarify, we agree on 200 licenses at \$60 each, with 1-year support plus a 6-month extension.

I: Yes, that all sounds fine.

T: Ok, it's a _____ (10)!

Solution 4

TechSolutions (T): So, shall we **get** (1) down to business, then?

Innovatech (I): Sure. We were looking to **make** (2) an order for 200 software licenses.

T: What sort of price did you have in **mind** (3)?

I: We were hoping **for** (4) a unit price of around \$50 per license.

T: Hmm, that might be difficult. Would you be willing to meet us **halfway** (5) at \$60?

I: If you include a one-year technical support package, we should be able to accept that price.

T: That seems **reasonable** (6). However, we'd need to see a bit more **flexibility** (7) on the payment terms.

I: I understand. Unfortunately, I don't have any more room to negotiate on the support fees.

T: Alright, let's not reach a **stalemate** (8) over this. How about we add a 6-month support extension instead?

I: That sounds good. I think we could **agree** (9) on that.

T: Great. So, to clarify, we agree on 200 licenses at \$60 each, with 1-year support plus a 6-month extension.

I: Yes, that all sounds fine.

T: Ok, it's a **deal** (10)!

Training 5. Conditional tenses.

Complete the sentences with the correct form of the verbs in brackets, depending on the type of conditional tense you need to use.

- ▶ 1. If you _____ (heat) water to 100°C, it _____ (boil). (Zero conditional).
- ▶ 2. If she _____ (study) harder, she _____ (pass) the exam. (First conditional).
- ▶ 3. If we _____ (leave) earlier, we _____ (not miss) the train. (Third conditional).
- ▶ 4. If she _____ (wake up) on time, she _____ (not be) late for the meeting (Third conditional).
- ▶ 5. If you _____ (press) this button, the machine _____ (start). (Zero conditional).
- ▶ 6. If we _____ (not hurry), we _____ (miss) the bus. (First conditional).
- ▶ 7. If I _____ (know) his number, I _____ (call) him. (Second conditional).
- ▶ 8. If he _____ (ask) politely, I _____ (help) him. (First conditional).
- ▶ 9. If they _____ (not spend) so much money, they _____ (save) more. (Third conditional).
- ▶ 10. If I _____ (win) the lottery last year, I _____ (travel) around the world. (Third conditional).

Solution 5

- ▶ 1. If you **heat** (heat) water to 100°C, it **boils** (boil). (Zero conditional).
- ▶ 2. If she **studies** (study) harder, she **will pass** (pass) the exam. (First conditional).
- ▶ 3. If we **had left** (leave) earlier, we **wouldn't have missed** (not miss) the train. (Third conditional).

- ▶ 4. If she **had woken up** (wake up) on time, she **wouldn't have been** (not be) late for the meeting (Third conditional).
- ▶ 5. If you **press** (press) this button, the machine **starts** (start). (Zero conditional).
- ▶ 6. If we **don't hurry** (not hurry), we **will miss** (miss) the bus. (First conditional).
- ▶ 7. If I **knew** (know) his number, I **would call** (call) him. (Second conditional).
- ▶ 8. If he **asks** (ask) politely, I **will help** (help) him. (First conditional).
- ▶ 9. If they **hadn't spent** (not spend) so much money, they **would have saved** (save) more. (Third conditional).
- ▶ 10. If I **had won** (win) the lottery last year, I **would have travelled** (travel) around the world. (Third conditional).